

BRIEF

Remote Work and Productivity: Evidence Review

August 2026 · Caspr Analysis

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TECHNOLOGY SECTOR BRIEF — REMOTE WORK AND PRODUCTIVITY: EVIDENCE REVIEW

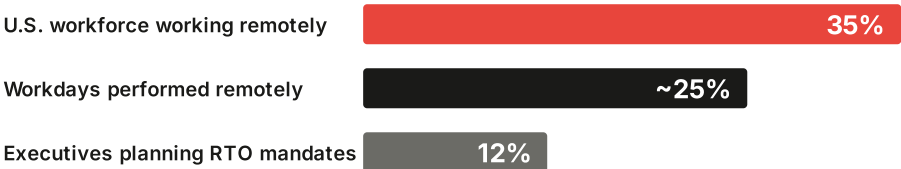
35%

of employed individuals worked remotely during 2025

Remote and hybrid work have stabilized as enduring operating models, with productivity and retention outcomes depending more on task fit, voluntariness, and employee preference alignment than on blanket return-to-office mandates.

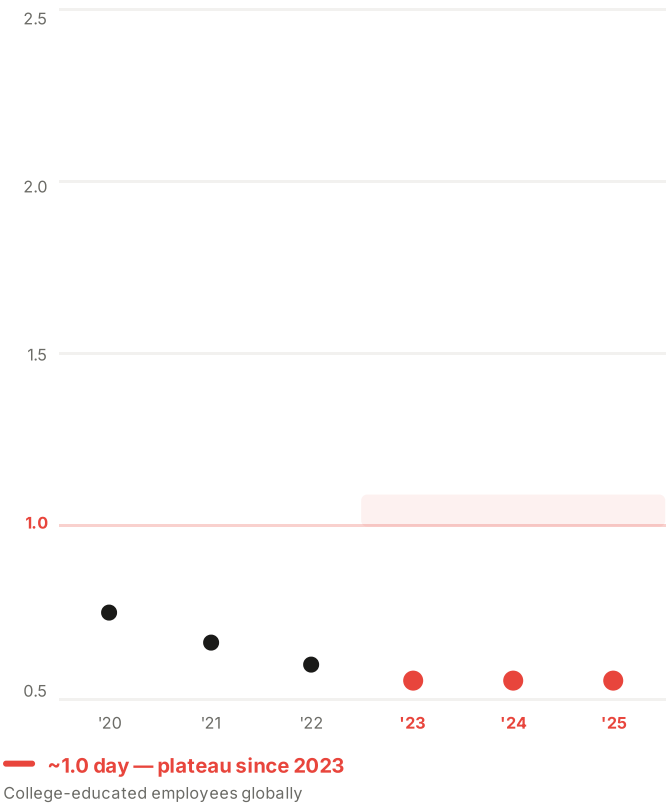
Remote work has plateaued at 35% participation despite minimal executive pushback, while delivering measurable productivity gains that RTO mandates barely dent.

WORKFORCE PARTICIPATION VS EXECUTIVE INTENT

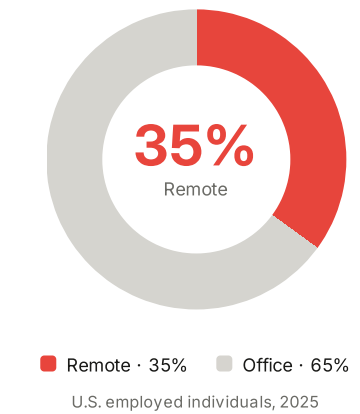


Worker adoption structurally outpaces executive resistance — remote work persists.

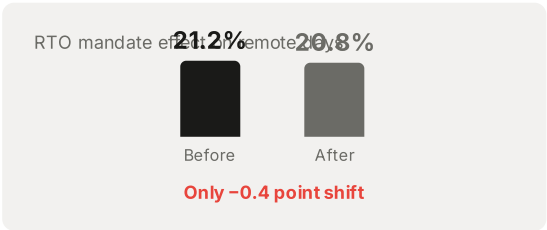
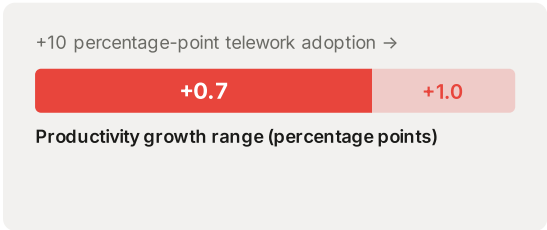
GLOBAL WFH DAYS / WEEK · TREND



WORK ARRANGEMENT MIX



PRODUCTIVITY GAIN & RTO MANDATE EFFECT



01 The State of Remote Work in 2025–2026

Remote work appears to have stabilized rather than reversed in 2025–2026. U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics data show that in 2025, 35% of employed people did some or all work at home on days worked ¹, while Stanford/NBER survey-based estimates place work-from-home at about one quarter of all paid U.S. workdays in 2025 ^{2 3}. Cross-national evidence likewise suggests persistence: average work-from-home rates among college-educated employees were roughly one day per week globally from 2023 through early 2025 ⁴. Stanford's February 2025 business survey also found that only 12% of executives with hybrid or remote staff planned an RTO mandate in the next year, and even those mandates barely changed expected paid workdays at home, from 21.2% to 20.8% ⁵.

Title — Trends in Work from Home Patterns and Projections for 2025

INDICATOR	VALUE
Employed people doing some/all work at home on workdays, U.S. 2025	35%
Estimated share of paid U.S. workdays done from home, 2025	~25%
Global average WFH days/week among college-educated employees, 2023–early 2025	~1.0
Executives planning RTO in next 12 months, Feb. 2025	12%

Source: Caspr analysis.

02 Productivity Evidence: Key Findings

The 2025–2026 evidence base is mixed but leans modestly positive for remote or hybrid work when tasks are suitable and arrangements are well matched. A 2026 meta-analysis covering 89 quantitative studies reports that remote-work usage and intensity are linked to performance, with effects varying by voluntariness, rating source, and whether studies were conducted before, during, or after the pandemic ⁶. At the industry level, BLS reports a positive relationship between remote work and total factor productivity across U.S. private industries, and its 2019–2023 analysis also links larger remote-work increases to lower growth in unit capital, energy, materials, and services costs ^{7 8}. Firm-level causal evidence remains heterogeneous: a 2025 IZA study of more than 6,500 French firms found that a 10-percentage-point increase in telework raised productivity growth by about 0.7–1.0 points in OLS and about 2.7 points in IV estimates ⁹, while earlier landmark experiments found hybrid work often preserves measured performance rather than raising it outright ¹⁰.

Title — Impact of Remote Work on Productivity and Performance: Key Findings from Recent Evidence

EVIDENCE TYPE	HEADLINE FINDING
2026 meta-analysis	Performance effects vary by intensity, voluntariness, and period studied

EVIDENCE TYPE	HEADLINE FINDING
U.S. industry-level BLS evidence	Remote work positively associated with TFP growth
2025 French firm-level causal study	+10 pp telework linked to +0.7 to +1.0 pp productivity growth; IV estimate ~+2.7 pp
Landmark hybrid field experiment	Performance ratings broadly unchanged under intermediate hybrid schedules

Source: Caspr analysis.

03 Return-to-Office Mandates and Their Effects

Recent evidence suggests that RTO mandates often have limited aggregate effects on work-from-home prevalence but can impose meaningful organizational costs. Stanford's 2025 executive survey found that announced RTOs would reduce paid workdays at home only marginally, from 21.2% to 20.8% ⁵. Experimental and quasi-experimental studies indicate some targeted benefits from in-person contact: a 2026 NBER field experiment found that one office day per month increased calls handled per hour by 7.8% and added 36 minutes of coworker communication in the following week ¹¹, while a Fortune 500 software-engineer study found proximity improves training and productivity ¹². At the same time, new causal evidence presented at the 2026 AEA meetings reports significant outflows of senior employees after RTO mandates at Microsoft, SpaceX, and Apple, implying potential human-capital and innovation costs ¹³.

04 Well-Being, Autonomy, and Performance

The strongest consistent moderator in the 2025–2026 literature is not remote work per se, but whether the arrangement fits worker preferences, autonomy needs, and job design. Pew reported in January 2025 that many remote workers would be likely to leave their job if they could no longer work from home, underscoring preference alignment as a retention variable rather than a peripheral attitude measure ¹⁴. A 2025 Organizational Dynamics review argues that remote work performs better when employees have fit and autonomy, whereas rigid mandates that ignore preferences can worsen disengagement and turnover intentions ¹⁵. On well-being specifically, a natural-experiment IZA study on an RTO mandate found little overall effect on health and well-being outcomes, with most estimates statistically insignificant and small in magnitude ¹⁶.

05 Conclusions and Research Implications

By 2025–2026, the evidence no longer supports a simple “remote work helps” or “remote work hurts” claim. The brief consensus is that hybrid and remote arrangements are now structurally persistent, average productivity effects are modest and context-dependent, and the main moderators are task suitability, intensity, voluntariness, and preference alignment ^{4 6 9}. For research-oriented readers, the main implication is to prioritize designs that separate individual

performance, team learning, and firm-level TFP, because these margins can move in different directions at the same time ^{7 11 12}. A second implication is that RTO should be studied as an organizational intervention with selection, retention, and human-capital effects, not merely as a location policy ^{13 14}.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Remote and hybrid work have stabilized as enduring operating models, with outcomes driven by fit and voluntariness.
- Only 12% of executives planned RTO mandates, and these appear to reduce remote workdays only slightly.
- RTO mandates can raise in-office collaboration modestly but risk experienced-worker losses and weaker innovation.

A Study on remote and hybrid work would cover productivity by work arrangement, return-to-office mandate effects on retention and innovation, and employee preference alignment and well-being — run it from your dashboard.